

African Methodist Church in Washington, D.C., was present as the Proclamation was printed off in a local newspaper: "Down Pennsylvania [Avenue] I ran as for my life, and when the people saw me coming with the paper in my hand they raised a shouting cheer that was almost deafening." It was from such heartfelt enthusiasm that thousands of Black volunteers for the Union army were raised.

This Final Emancipation Proclamation included a provision for enlisting formerly enslaved men, and thus the seeds for the United States Colored Troops (USCT) were sown. Various states had already begun recruitment of free Black citizens into segregated regiments, but now those recently liberated could join as well.

In Democratic parts of the North, especially in districts that had voted against Lincoln in 1860, many white people frowned upon the new war measure. Activities increased among Copperheads (Northern Democrats opposed to the war), and newspaper editors blasted the administration for abandoning the preservation of the Union and embracing emancipation instead. One Union regiment deserted almost to a man upon hearing the news. But in most sections of the loyal states, public opinion was cautiously optimistic that emancipation might hasten the end of the war.